

of raw material and finished product. Soon, it proved to be the new captive traffic for the railways. The Bengal–Nagpur Railway (BNR) undertook several initiatives, including production of wagons to carry steel and iron ore in bulk. It also commissioned and constructed the Inner Harbour at the Visakhapatnam Port in 1933 to facilitate the export of manganese ore from the Central Provinces.

Challenges

Post-Independence, it became necessary to ensure smooth and efficient freight services, as India embarked on a programme of planned economic development. As freight facilitated economic growth, there was a multiplier effect on it. Commodities such as coal, fertilizer, cement, petroleum products, food grain, iron ore, raw material to produce steel, and steel itself were criss-crossing the country on rail tracks in a bid towards economic development through an industrial boom. There were instances when lines were laid specifically for freight. In one such example, three lines were constructed from the Bailadila mines (in present-day Chhattisgarh) to move 6 million tonnes of iron ore to Visakhapatnam for export to Japan (see [Iron Strength](#)).

However, outdated and limited rolling stock, such as wagons with vacuum brakes and incompatible couplings, and complex, time-consuming procedures, such as the option of booking individual wagons to transport materials, restricted the railways from truly utilizing freight transport. These cut severely into train operations, leading to long delays in freight and passenger movement. The Indian Railways sought innovations in its freight operations.